decided to examine the fundamental question of the relationship between India and Bharat through the prisms of civilisation and the Constitution, and what it meant, if anything, to the State and to the society at large.

To this end, I began to write a few pieces for *Firstpost*[12] and *Open Magazine*[13] capturing my views. In particular, I argued against approaching the Constitution with a sense of affected and exaggerated religiosity without understanding it in the broader context of the civilisation, which, I contended, was the primary canvas as well as the object of protection. To romanticise and venerate the Constitution, I argued, was to conflate the means with the end to the detriment of the civilisation. In a nutshell, I took the position that the Constitution must be alive to history to serve its intended purpose.

These were my tentative beginnings on this intersection, and my thoughts took better shape when I spoke at a conference in Chennai on the Hindu character of princely States based on the research that was put together for the Shri Padmanabhaswamy Temple case. Around this time, ideas for a book had started taking shape in my mind and quite a few well-wishers had begun to ask me to pen my thoughts in the form of a book. However, I first wanted to run my ideas through a series of pieces before capturing them coherently in the form of a book. This, I felt, would also help me to assess if I could balance my professional commitments as an arguing counsel with my writing initiatives. While I was still mulling over the prospect of writing a book, the world was hit by the COVID-19 pandemic. I decided to use the respite provided by the lockdown to read up more on civilisational and constitutional aspects before starting a column.

I set out to try and make sense of existing ideological divides across the political spectrum in Bharat. It seemed to me that regardless of labels, there was a common acceptance of the colonialised version of Bharat's history, especially in matters of human rights, religion, education, environment, development, caste and gender. In fact, there seemed to be a shared view across ideologies that there was indeed a 'universal' and uniform moral standard that all 'civilised societies' *must* adhere to. Barring a handful of scholars, such as Ram Swarup, Sitaram Goel, Dharampal, Koenraad Elst, Dr. S.N. Balagangadhara and Dr. Jakob De Roover, very few seemed interested in challenging the Western-normative framework which informed these so-called universal standards. Even those who publicly extolled the Indic civilisation for its spiritual, philosophical, legal and epistemological